

The Three Brothers

Three elderly brothers, all very **short-sighted**, lived in a large house on the **outskirts** of a city in China.

One day the youngest brother suggested that he should **take charge** of the finances.

"Elder brother's **sight** is so bad, he cannot see how much money he's receiving or giving," he said, "and people **take advantage of** his disability."

"As if you can see better," **sneered** the second-youngest brother. "If you're saying our finances should be handled by the one who has the best sight, then it is I who should be given charge. I can see better than either of you."

"I have my doubts about that," said the eldest brother. "Let's settle this once and for all. I've heard the **monastery** is **putting up** a **tablet inscribed** with a **saying**, above the main doorway, tonight. Let's go there tomorrow and test our vision. Whoever can read the **inscription** with the least **strain** will get charge of our money. Agreed?"

"Agreed," said his brothers **in unison**.

"Good! Now go away and let **me** get a few **winks**."

As soon as they had gone, the eldest brother **sneaked out** of the house and went to the monastery where he met a monk.

"I've heard you're putting up an inscription over the doorway," he said. "Can you tell me what the inscription reads?"

"**Certainly**. It's a **quotation** from **Confucius**. It reads: Be Honest At All Times."

The brother went away **chuckling** at his **cleverness**. A little later the second brother arrived there.

"Can you tell me what the inscription you are going to put up over the doorway reads?" he said to the monk.

"Everybody seems to want to know," said the man. "It reads: Be Honest At All Times."

"Is there any decoration around it?"



"The tablet has a flowery border."

The second brother went away very **pleased** with himself. **Hardly** had he gone when the third brother arrived there. He too enquired about the inscription and on being told what it was, asked if there was any other writing on it.

"Only the donor's name, Wang Lee, at the bottom," said the monk.

The next morning the three brothers **made their way to** the monastery.

"There's the inscription," said the oldest when they **drew near** the entrance. "I can clearly **make out** the writing. It reads: Be Honest At All Times."

"Your sight is better than I thought," said the second brother. "But definitely not better than mine. Can you see the decoration around the inscription?"

"Decoration? What decoration?"

"There's a **floral** decoration all around the tablet," said the brother, **triumphantly**.

"Very good, very good," **applauded** the youngest brother. "But can either of you see any other writing on the tablet besides the inscription?"

"Other writing?" **intoned** the second brother, his face falling. "What other writing is there?"

"The name of the donor, Wang Lee," said the youngest brother, pointing. "Can't you see it? It's at that corner."

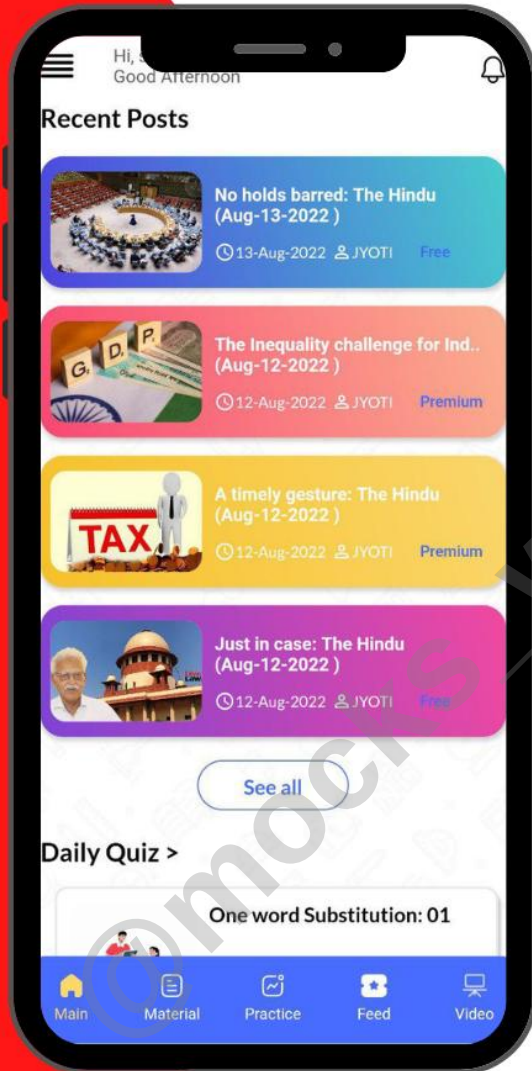
The monk they had talked to the previous evening came out of the monastery just then.

"Oh, you've come to see the inscription," he said. "So sorry. We couldn't put it up yesterday evening. We are going to put it up today."

Vocabulary

1. **Short-sighted** (adjective) – myopic, nearsighted, unseeing, visually impaired, shortsighted निकटदृष्टि से ग्रस्त
2. **Outskirt** (noun) – edge, border, suburb, periphery, fringe नगर सीमा
3. **Take charge** (phrase) – assume control, handle, lead, manage, supervise जिम्मेदारी लेना
4. **Sight** (noun) – vision, eyesight, view, perception, visibility दृष्टि
5. **Take advantage of** (phrase) – exploit, misuse, manipulate, deceive, benefit unfairly फायदा उठाना
6. **Sneer** (verb) – mock, scoff, taunt, jeer, ridicule ताना मारना
7. **Monastery** (noun) – abbey, cloister, temple, ashram, convent मठ
8. **Put up** (phrasal verb) – install, place, fix, display, set up लगाना
9. **Tablet** (noun) – plaque, panel, board, slab, nameplate पट्टिका
10. **Inscribe** (verb) – carve, engrave, etch, write, imprint उकेरना
11. **Saying** (noun) – proverb, adage, maxim, expression, quote कहावत
12. **Inscription** (noun) – engraving, writing, legend, text, etching शिलालेख
13. **Strain** (noun) – stress, effort, tension, pressure, struggle तनाव
14. **In unison** (phrase) – together, simultaneously, collectively, in chorus, with one voice एक स्वर में
15. **Get a few winks** (phrase) – rest, sleep, nap, snooze, doze थोड़ी देर सोना
16. **Sneak out** (phrasal verb) – slip out, leave quietly, escape, slip away, creep out चुपचाप निकल जाना
17. **Certainly** (adverb) – definitely, surely, undoubtedly, clearly, of course निश्चित रूप से
18. **Quotation** (noun) – citation, excerpt, passage, phrase, extract उद्धरण
19. **Confucius** (noun) – Chinese philosopher, sage, thinker, teacher, reformer कन्फ्यूशियस
20. **Chuckle** (at) (verb) – laugh softly, giggle, snicker, snigger, smile धीरे से हँसना
21. **Cleverness** (noun) – intelligence, smartness, wit, shrewdness, ingenuity चतुराई
22. **Pleased** (adjective) – happy, satisfied, content, delighted, glad प्रसन्न

23. **Hardly** (adverb) – barely, scarcely, just, rarely, seldom मुश्किल से
24. **Make one's way to** (phrase) – move towards, approach, reach, proceed to, head to की ओर बढ़ना
25. **Draw near** (phrase) – come close, approach, move closer, near, arrive निकट आना
26. **Make out** (phrasal verb) – see clearly, discern, recognize, perceive, identify पढ़ पाना
27. **Floral** (adjective) – flowery, decorated with flowers, botanical, plant-based, blooming फूलों से सजाया हुआ
28. **Triumphantly** (adverb) – victoriously, proudly, successfully, exultantly, joyfully विजयी भाव से
29. **Applaud** (verb) – praise, clap, cheer, appreciate, hail सराहना करना
30. **Intone** (verb) – say, chant, recite, pronounce, utter भावपूर्वक कहना



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